

AGE OF MYTHOS

Northeast — Chapter 1 — Rise of Legends

Northeast · Pragjyotisha · English Edition

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Arunodaya Kshetra — The War Between Dawn And Night

Arunachal Pradesh sees the first sunrise in India. Every morning, while the rest of the country sleeps, the hills of Arunachal catch the sun and hold it like a gift. The Great Hornbills spread their massive wings to warm them in the new light, and the gayals stand on ridges like silhouettes waiting to be painted.

Udayagiri was born at exactly the moment the sun crested the Mishmi Hills — the first child born in the first light. The village elders named him Dawn-Walker because, they said, the sun had paused in its rising to watch him arrive.

His sister had been born three years earlier, at midnight, under a sky so dark that the stars seemed to press against the earth. The elders said nothing about her birth. Some say they were afraid.

When Tamasi was taken — pulled from her home by men who came through the mountain passes in the dark — Udayagiri was too young to understand. He grew up knowing only that he had a sister once, and that she was gone. He searched for her. He found her.

She was living in a cave system that stretched for miles beneath the border mountains, and she had made it her kingdom. The cave-dwellers who followed her had never seen the sun — children born underground, raised in torchlight, pale as cave-fish and deadly as the darkness that hid them.

"Come home," Udayagiri said, standing at the cave's entrance with dawn spilling in behind him like liquid gold.

Tamasi screamed. Not in rage — in pain. The light burned her, not physically but psychically. Every ray of light was a reminder of the morning she was taken, of the sunrise she was watching when the hands grabbed her. Light meant vulnerability. Darkness meant safety.

"Make it stop," she whispered. And she struck the cave wall with her night-staff, and the darkness poured out like water, extinguishing the dawn that Udayagiri carried with him.

The Battle of the Border Cave was fought in conditions that favored neither — half the cave was lit by Udayagiri's dawn-spear, half was shrouded in Tamasi's night. The boundary

between light and dark was a physical line on the stone floor, and they fought across it — he retreating into light when wounded, she retreating into dark. Neither could enter the other's domain.

The Great Hornbills circled outside, unable to enter the cave. The gayals lowed on the ridge, disturbed by the wrongness of a dawn that ended at a cave-mouth.

Baba Parashar, watching from above the clouds, said: "This is not a war. This is a sibling argument that the universe is taking too seriously."

He is right. But sibling arguments in the Hulmane-The-Saga have consequences measured in kingdoms.

Udayagiri has not given up. Every morning, he forges a new spear in the dawn and walks to the cave entrance. Every morning, his sister's darkness pushes the light back. And every morning, the light gains one inch more.

He believes — the eternal optimist — that one day the dawn will reach her. And she will remember that light is not an enemy. It is a brother, reaching into the dark.

Beyul Kshetra — The Monk The Mountain And The Thief

Kanchenjunga is not just a mountain. It is a deity, a promise, and a warning. The third-highest peak in the world holds five treasures in its five peaks — salt, grain, weapons, medicine, and scripture — and the Sikkimese believe that revealing these treasures would bring either salvation or apocalypse, depending on the world's worthiness.

The hero who bears the mountain's name is its human reflection: five virtues in one body. Kanchenjunga the man entered a monastery at age eight and was expected to spend his life in meditation. Instead, the world came to him — in the form of a red panda.

The panda appeared at the monastery door during a blizzard, carrying in its mouth a scroll that had been missing from the monastery's library for a century. The scroll contained a prophecy: "When the mountain's treasure is threatened, the mountain's peace must become a weapon."

Kanchenjunga did not want to be a weapon. He was a monk. He wanted tea and sutras and the sound of prayer bells in the morning mist. But the red panda stayed at his side, and its eyes — amber, ancient, knowing — told him that gentleness itself could be the weapon.

His prayer wheel mace was not forged — it grew. The monastery's prayer wheels, spun by wind and water for centuries, accumulated spiritual energy so dense that the metal warped. Kanchenjunga shaped the warped metal into a mace, and when he spun it, the mantras embedded in the metal created barriers of force that nothing could penetrate.

He has never struck anyone with it. He has only ever defended.

Yaksha-Nidhi came to Sikkim seeking the five treasures. He had already taken the salt — extracting it from a sacred lake in a single night. He had taken the grain — the special rice that grows only in Sikkim's terraced fields, stealing the entire genetic stock. He was reaching for the weapons — the celestial arms hidden in Kanchenjunga's third peak — when the monk appeared.

The confrontation was not violent. Kanchenjunga stood on the mountain path, prayer wheel spinning, and asked: "What are you looking for?"

"The treasures," Yaksha-Nidhi answered.

"Why?"

"Because they are hidden, and hidden things call to me."

"What if they are hidden to protect you, not from you?"

This question stopped the thief. Not because it was wise — Yaksha-Nidhi had heard wisdom before and ignored it — but because it was the first time anyone had suggested that the treasures' concealment might be an act of compassion rather than hoarding.

He left without the weapons. But he will be back. The Blood Pheasants — those red-feathered birds that live only at extreme altitudes — have been seen descending to lower ground, a sign that something is disturbing the mountain's upper reaches.

Kanchenjunga's mother has been waiting thirty-seven years for her son to leave the monastery and come home. He sends her letters carried by red pandas. She reads them, folds them into prayer flags, and hangs them in the wind.

The wind carries the prayers to the mountain. The mountain holds its treasures. The monk holds his prayer wheel.

And somewhere between the monastery and the summit, a thief with empty hands sits on a rock, trying to understand why emptiness no longer satisfies him.

Dzukou Rashtra — The Dao And The Dream

Nagaland's history is written in headhunting tattoos. Before the missionaries came, before the British drew borders, the Naga tribes measured a man's worth by the heads on his wall. Each head was a battle won, a village defended, a youth's passage into adulthood. The tattoos recorded these achievements — and to this day, the oldest Naga elders carry facial tattoos that are maps of kills they made in their youth.

Dzulevira's father wanted a son. He wanted a warrior who would carry the dao and the skull-necklace. He got a daughter instead — and Dzulevira spent her first twenty years proving that a daughter could carry the dao better than any son. She mastered all sixteen tribal fighting styles, learned the ancient art of head-taking (in theory, never in practice), and became the finest warrior in Nagaland.

Then she did something no warrior had done before: she refused to kill.

Her full-body tattoo — the gayal in geometric Naga patterns covering her from neck to ankle — was granted not by the tattoo council but by the tattoo itself. It appeared overnight, the night she united the sixteen tribes. For the first time, Ao, Angami, Konyak, Sema, Lotha, Chakhesang, Rengma, Zeliang, Chang, Khamniungan, Yimchunger, Sangtam, Pochury, Phom, Kuki, and Zeme-Liangmai representatives sat in one council and spoke as one.

Ao-Rakshas watched this unity and seethed. Unity through peace meant the death of the old warrior identity. If the Nagas no longer take heads, what are they? Farmers? Office workers? The ghost of every headhunter who died proud screamed in protest.

His first strike was subtle. He touched a young Konyak warrior's shoulder at the Hornbill Festival, and the young man felt something ancient surge through him — the urge to fight, to take, to prove. The warrior attacked a rival tribe's dancer, and the ensuing brawl nearly destroyed the festival.

Dzulevira stopped it by standing between the two groups, dao sheathed, arms open. She took a blow meant for someone else — and did not retaliate. The shock of a full-body-marked warrior choosing to bleed rather than fight broke the frenzy.

Her father, watching from the crowd, finally understood. His daughter had not rejected the warrior way — she had evolved it. Taking a head proves you can kill. Taking a blow proves

you can endure. The second requires more courage.

Ao-Rakshas retreated to the Saramati peak, where the skull-trees grow — trees draped with the skulls of ancient kills, each one whispering the pride of the old ways. He is building an army of ghosts — warriors who died believing their way was right, and who will fight to prove it.

Dzulevira sharpens her dao each evening. She has never used it on a person. She hopes she never will. But the Dzukou Valley lilies are blooming late this year, and Liyaba's ghost walks with heavier steps.

The old ways do not die easily. They haunt.

Ganda Kshetra — Rhino Knight

All Kingdoms › India › Pragjyotisha (Northeast) › Assam › The Rhino Knight

ASSAM — THE NORTHEAST KINGDOM The Rhino Knight of Kaziranga The Story of Kamalavarna, the Lotus Shield

The Lotus Shield — Horn of the Brahmaputra

State:Assam

Region:Northeast India (Pragjyotisha)

Sacred Animal:Indian One-horned Rhinoceros

Companion:Vajrakavacha (Diamond Armor)

Weapon:Tower shield Kavach (Armor) & rhino-horn mace

Tattoo Stage:Stage 4 — Full Body

Tall and solidly built with skin the color of lotus petals — a soft brown with pinkish undertones that gave her family name. Her face is broad and kind, with the strength of the Brahmaputra Valley in her features. She wears layered armor inspired by rhino hide — overlapping plates that deflect blades. A single lotus is always woven into her hair.

Chapter I

Kaziranga, the Golden Grass — Age 3

The elephant grass of Kaziranga grows taller than a grown man. In the early monsoon it turns the color of old gold, and when the wind moves through it the entire floodplain ripples like a living sea. It was into this sea of gold that Padmavati Kamalavarna carried her three-year-old daughter one dawn in the month of Bohag, when the Brahmaputra ran high and the air tasted of river clay and wild jasmine.

The elders had forbidden it. Vajrakavacha — the great bull rhinoceros, three thousand kilograms of armored fury — had killed two poachers that season and gored a forest guard who had ventured too close. He was the undisputed lord of the eastern marshes, a creature so ancient and so fearsome that even the other rhinos gave him wide berth. His horn was

nearly two feet long, stained dark at the base, and his hide bore the scars of a hundred territorial battles. No one approached Vajrakavacha. No one.

But Padmavati had seen the mark. On her daughter's right shoulder blade, glowing faintly in the lamplight of their bamboo home, was the unmistakable imprint of a rhinoceros footprint. Three toes, broad and deep, etched into the child's skin as though the earth itself had pressed its seal upon her. The Kamalavarna clan had carried the rhino mark for four hundred years, but never had it appeared so early, and never had it pulsed with its own faint violet light.

They found him at the edge of the marsh where the elephant grass thinned into mud flats. He was standing perfectly still, his enormous head lowered toward the water, his small keen eyes catching the first light of day. The ground trembled faintly with each of his breaths. Padmavati set the child down in the grass twenty paces away and stepped back, every instinct screaming at her to snatch her daughter up and run.

The little girl did not cry. She did not run. She walked forward on unsteady legs, her bare feet sinking into the warm mud, her tiny hands reaching out toward the grey mountain before her. Vajrakavacha raised his head. His ears swiveled forward. A low rumble rolled from his chest — a sound that carried through the ground and up through the child's feet and into her bones.

He lowered his massive head until his horn nearly touched the earth, and the child placed both her small hands on his snout. His skin was warm and rough, like sun-heated stone. His breath washed over her in great hot gusts. And the mark on her shoulder flared once, brilliant violet, and then settled into a steady glow that would never fully fade again. The bond was made. Not chosen by either party, not forced, not earned. Simply recognized, the way the river recognizes the sea.

"She touched the unkillable thing, and the unkillable thing was gentle. That was the first miracle. Everything after was just consequence."

— Padmavati Kamalavarna, mother of the Lotus Shield

Chapter II

The Grasslands of Kaziranga — Ages 6 to 12

She ran barefoot. Always barefoot. The soles of her feet hardened until they were nearly as tough as the rhino hide she would later model her armor upon, and beneath that leather-

thick skin her nerves remained exquisitely sensitive. She could feel a herd of wild buffalo shifting direction two hundred meters away. She could feel the distinctive three-toed compression of a rhinoceros footfall and know, without looking, whether it was Vajrakavacha or one of the younger bulls. The earth spoke to her, and she listened with her feet.

Each morning before the sun crested the Karbi hills, she rose from whatever patch of ground she had slept on and found the herd. The rhinos of Kaziranga move at dawn — slow, deliberate migrations from sleeping grounds to grazing meadows, following paths worn into the landscape over generations. She matched their pace exactly. Not ahead, never behind, always alongside. She learned to breathe as they breathed — deep, slow, rhythmic inhalations that filled the belly before the chest. She learned to move as they moved — with an economy of motion that wasted nothing, every step placed with the precision of a creature that weighs as much as a small truck and cannot afford to stumble.

The training was brutal in the way that nature is brutal: without malice, without mercy, without explanation. She broke three toes in her first year when she misjudged the soft edge of a wallowing pit and a young rhino stepped on her foot. She set the toes herself, using river clay as a splint, and was running again in two weeks. She contracted leeches, tick fever, and a skin infection from sleeping in damp grass that left a constellation of pale scars across her left forearm. She was charged by a wild boar, treed by a water buffalo, and once spent an entire night chest-deep in marsh water hiding from a Bengal tiger that had wandered into rhino territory.

But the mornings. The mornings made everything worth enduring. The mist rising off the Brahmaputra like the breath of a sleeping god. The elephant grass catching the first gold of dawn and holding it, trembling, as if the light were too precious to release. The sound of Vajrakavacha's breathing beside her — that deep, resonant bellows-sound, steady as a heartbeat, ancient as the river itself. The smell of wet earth and crushed grass and the warm, musky, strangely comforting scent of rhinoceros hide. She would run through that golden world with the great grey beast beside her and feel, in those moments, that she had never been born into a human body at all.

She ate what the land provided. Wild herbs — brahmi for clarity, ashwagandha for endurance, tulsi for immunity — supplemented with the river fish she caught with her bare hands using techniques she learned by watching the fishing cats at the water's edge. She slept under the stars or in the hollow between Vajrakavacha's legs, curled against his warm

belly, listening to the gurgling machinery of his digestion as it processed forty kilograms of grass. She grew tall, broad-shouldered, solid. Her muscles developed not the sculpted definition of a gymnasium athlete but the dense, functional power of someone who had spent six years moving with animals through rough terrain. She was thirteen years old, and she could run for four hours without stopping, stand motionless for six, and sense a human footstep at three hundred meters through vibrations in the earth.

"The dojo teaches you to fight. The grassland teaches you to live. One of these lessons outlasts the other."

— Kamalavarna, on why she never trained indoors

Chapter III

The Open Floodplain — Ages 12 to 18

The first time she charged at Vajrakavacha, she woke up face-down in a mud wallow forty feet from where she had started. Her left arm was numb. Two of her ribs made a clicking sound when she breathed. The great rhinoceros stood exactly where she had left him, chewing grass, utterly indifferent to the fact that he had just launched a sixty-kilogram girl through the air with a casual flick of his armored head.

She charged him again the next day. And the day after. And the day after that. For six years.

The exercises would have seemed insane to anyone watching. A teenage girl sprinting directly at a three-ton animal, planting her feet at the last possible moment, and trying to redirect his charge by pressing against his shoulder and using his own momentum to pivot his path. It was like trying to redirect a landslide with your hands. For the first two years, the result was always the same: Kamalavarna sailing through the air, landing hard, getting up, and doing it again. She broke her collarbone. She cracked her sternum. She dislocated her right shoulder so many times that the joint eventually developed a permanent looseness that she later learned to weaponize, whipping her shield arm through angles that would have torn a normal shoulder apart.

But slowly — so slowly that the progress was measured in millimeters and seconds — she began to learn. Not how to stop the unstoppable, because Vajrakavacha could not be stopped. But how to read the signals that preceded his charge: the slight flattening of his ears, the shift of weight onto his back legs, the particular snort that meant he was about to

move rather than merely breathe. She learned the geometry of momentum — that two tons moving in a straight line could be nudged, if you timed it perfectly, into a gentle curve. She learned to plant her shield at the precise angle where his force flowed around her rather than through her.

By fifteen, she could redirect his charge by forty-five degrees. By sixteen, she could spin him completely. By seventeen, she performed the act that no warrior in the Kamalavarna lineage had ever achieved: she stood directly in the path of Vajrakavacha's full charge — the ground shaking, the air splitting, three thousand kilograms of prehistoric armor bearing down on her at thirty-five kilometers per hour — and brought him to a stop. Not by overpowering him. By reading the rhythm of his stride, planting her shield at the exact moment his front feet left the ground, and absorbing his momentum through her knees, her hips, and the deep muscles of her core, dispersing the force into the earth beneath her feet.

The shield technique she developed during those years had no name in any martial tradition, because no martial tradition had ever required a human being to fight like a rhinoceros. It was entirely defensive — a system of angles and timing and immovable patience designed to absorb any force the world could deliver and remain standing. She called it nothing. It needed no name. It was simply how she stood.

"Everyone wants to know how to deliver an unstoppable blow. No one asks how to become the thing that cannot be moved. That second question is harder. And more useful."

— Kamalavarna, when asked about her fighting style

Chapter IV

The Bond Between Two Souls

Warriors tell stories of power. Poets tell stories of love. This chapter belongs to the poets.

Vajrakavacha recognized her footsteps from a mile away. The forest guards of Kaziranga documented this with scientific precision: whenever Kamalavarna approached from any direction, the great bull would raise his head, rotate his ears toward the sound, and begin walking to meet her before she was even visible. He did not do this for any other human. He did not do this for any other rhino. The vibration of her particular gait — left foot landing slightly harder than the right, a legacy of the broken toes that never healed quite straight — was as distinctive to him as a name spoken aloud.

He bellowed when she was sad. Not the aggressive territorial roar that sent other animals scattering, but a low, sustained vocalization from deep in his chest — a sound so low that it was felt rather than heard, a vibration that traveled through the ground and up through her bones and settled somewhere in her ribcage like a second heartbeat. The Assamese biologists who studied the pair called it a "contact call" and published papers about interspecies emotional bonding. Kamalavarna called it his way of saying I am here.

She learned his language in return. The quick double-snort that meant something is wrong. The long exhale through flared nostrils that meant I am content. The way he would press his horn gently — gently, despite the fact that this horn had gored tigers and shattered tree trunks — against her shoulder to say move with me. The rumbling purr, felt through the ground rather than heard through the air, that meant he was deeply at peace. She could hold entire conversations with him in a language that no other human being understood, a private vocabulary of snorts and huffs and silences that said more than words ever could.

There was the time the quicksand caught her. The floodplain of the Brahmaputra is treacherous after the monsoon — patches of earth that look solid but are in fact liquid mud over ancient silt, ready to swallow a human being to the waist in seconds and to the chest in minutes. She went in up to her hips before she realized what had happened. The more she struggled, the deeper she sank. Cold mud closed around her thighs, her waist, pressing the air from her lungs with the slow, patient pressure of the earth reclaiming what walked upon it.

Vajrakavacha came at her distress call — not her voice, which the mud had stolen, but the frantic pounding of her fists against the surface, transmitted through the ground in a pattern he had never heard from her before. He circled the quicksand patch, reading the ground with his own ancient instincts, and then did something that no observer could explain: he lay down at the edge of the solid ground and stretched his enormous head toward her. She grabbed his horn with both hands, and he stood — slowly, patiently, his massive neck muscles flexing against her sixty kilograms plus the suction of the mud — and pulled her free. She lay on solid ground gasping, covered in grey silt, and he stood over her, snorting his something is wrong call, nudging her with his horn until she laughed and pushed his ridiculous worried face away.

And there was the thunderstorm. Rhinos, despite their armor, are afraid of thunder. Not the rain — they love the rain, wallowing in the mud it creates with obvious pleasure. But

the crack of lightning and the bone-deep percussion of close thunder sends them into a panic that is terrifying to witness in an animal of that size. On the night of the great Bohag storm, when the sky split open and the rain fell in sheets and the Brahmaputra rose four feet in an hour, Vajrakavacha paced and bellowed, his massive body trembling, his eyes rolling white.

Kamalavarna sat in the mud beside him. She pressed her forehead against his neck, wrapped her arms as far around his massive body as they would go — which was not far — and sang. An old Assamese lullaby her mother had sung to her, about a river that carried its children safely to the sea. She sang it over and over, her voice barely audible above the storm, her breath warm against his hide. His trembling slowed. His breathing deepened. By the third repetition, he had folded his legs beneath him and lowered his head to the ground. By the fifth, he was asleep. She sang until the storm passed, soaked to the bone, cradling the head of a three-ton animal in her lap, and she would later say it was the most important thing she had ever done.

"People ask me what makes me strong. I tell them: I am not strong. I am anchored. There is a difference. A strong person can be broken. An anchored person has something that holds them to the earth. My anchor weighs three thousand kilograms and snores."

— Kamalavarna, at the Council of Northeast Heroes

Chapter V

Kaziranga, the Darkest Dawn

They came with military precision. Fifteen men, armed with suppressed rifles, night-vision equipment, and a tranquilizer strong enough to drop an elephant. They had satellite imagery of the rhino grazing patterns. They had bribed a forest guard for the patrol schedules. They had a helicopter waiting at a cleared field eleven kilometers east of the park boundary. They were not poachers in any traditional sense. They were a special operations unit employed by a transnational syndicate that moved rhinoceros horn across borders with the efficiency of a logistics corporation.

They killed seven rhinos in four hours. Each animal was dropped with a combination of tranquilizer and a high-caliber round to the skull. The horns were removed with electric saws — the sound masked by the monsoon rains that the syndicate had timed their operation to coincide with. Seven horns, worth more per gram than gold or cocaine,

packaged in climate-controlled cases and moving toward the extraction point before the last body had finished cooling.

They should have left then. But someone wanted Vajrakavacha.

The great bull's horn was legendary — the longest of any living rhinoceros in Kaziranga, and the syndicate's buyer had specified it by name. They found him at the eastern marsh, and the tranquilizer dart hit him in the neck. He staggered but did not fall. A second dart. He swayed. And then the shooter, impatient, used the rifle. The bullet entered below his left shoulder blade, traveled through muscle and fat, and came to rest against his lower spine. Vajrakavacha crashed to his knees. He tried to rise and could not. His back legs had stopped working.

Kamalavarna felt it through the earth.

She was three kilometers away, sleeping in a ranger's outpost, when the vibration hit her feet like an electric shock. Not the rhythmic tremor of a rhino moving, not the sharp percussion of a territorial stomp. This was something she had never felt before — a massive body hitting the ground and not getting up. Her eyes flew open in the darkness. She was running before she was fully awake, barefoot, wearing only her sleeping clothes, the tower shield Kavach left behind because there was no time. There was no time for anything.

She found him at dawn. The poachers had fled when Vajrakavacha refused to die — even paralyzed, he had swung his horn at anyone who approached, and the team leader had decided the risk was not worth the reward. They left him bleeding in the tall grass, the rain washing his blood into the mud in pink rivers, his breathing a terrible wet rasp that Kamalavarna heard from fifty meters away and that stopped her heart.

She knelt in the mud beside him. She lifted his head — that enormous head, eighty kilograms of bone and horn and the gentlest soul she had ever known — and placed it in her lap. His eyes found hers. They were clouded with pain but steady. His breathing came in shallow, labored gasps. The bullet was pressing against his spinal cord. Every breath was a battle.

She did not cry. She did not scream. She pressed her forehead against his horn and closed her eyes and felt something inside her shatter like a dam hit by a wall of water. And what poured through the break was not grief. It was something older, hotter, and infinitely more dangerous.

Her tattoo erupted.

The rhinoceros footprint on her shoulder blade, which had grown over the years to cover her shoulder and upper arm — Stage Two of the Chihnachakra — began to move. The ink writhed beneath her skin like a living thing, flowing down her arm, across her ribs, over her back. She could feel it spreading: a burning that was not quite pain, a pressure that was not quite weight. The full rhino form was emerging — legs, body, the armored plates, the great horn rising from the mark's forehead to point at the sky. By the time the sun cleared the eastern hills, her entire right side was covered. Stage Three. Achieved not through a trial of combat or a test of endurance, but through the purest form of anguish a human heart can contain — the knowledge that the thing you love most in the world is dying, and you cannot stop it.

"The tattoo does not measure power. It measures truth. And there is no truth deeper than what you feel when you hold the dying."

— Regional Scholar Bhupen Kalikota, on the Kaziranga Awakening

Chapter VI

Across Three States — Seven Days of Reckoning

She left Vajrakavacha in the care of the Kaziranga veterinary team and walked back to the ranger outpost. She put on her armor. She picked up Kavach. And then she followed the tracks.

The poachers had been professional enough to cover their trail from any normal tracker. But Kamalavarna did not track like a normal human. She tracked like a rhinoceros. She read the earth through her feet — the compressed soil where vehicles had passed, the disturbed root patterns where boots had crushed undergrowth, the faint chemical residue of tranquilizer leaking from improperly sealed cases. She followed the trail at a dead run, and the tattoo on her body pulsed with each step, feeding her strength she did not know she possessed.

Day one: she found the helicopter landing site. The pilot had stayed behind to sanitize the scene. He saw a woman emerge from the elephant grass and had exactly enough time to register the glowing purple tattoo covering half her body before Kavach hit his helicopter's tail rotor. The machine would never fly again. Neither would the pilot, who woke up three

hours later with both arms zip-tied to a tree and a broken jaw that would require surgical reconstruction. She took his radio and his phone.

Day two: Meghalaya. The horn transport team had crossed the state border using logging roads. She found their truck at a refueling stop in the Garo Hills. Three armed men. She came through the truck's windshield shield-first. The sound of safety glass exploding inward, followed immediately by the concussion of Kavach slamming into the dashboard, was the last clear memory any of the three men retained. She recovered two horns and left the men for the Meghalaya police, who found them unconscious and neatly bound in the truck's cargo area.

Day three and four: the syndicate realized they were being hunted. They split into cells and scattered. It did not help. Kamalavarna moved with the relentless patience of her namesake animal — she did not hurry, she did not tire, she did not stop. She slept two hours a night, ate what she found, and ran. Through the Khasi Hills, across the Jaintia Plateau, into the river valleys of southern Assam. She found them in ones and twos, in safe houses and roadside motels, in the back rooms of shops that fronted for the horn trade. Each confrontation was brief and decisive. She fought like the thing she was becoming: a rhinoceros in human form. She charged through doors. She shrugged off blows that would have felled any other fighter. When a man emptied a pistol clip at her from ten feet, the bullets sparked off Kavach and she kept coming.

Day five: Nagaland border. The syndicate's regional commander, a man who had organized the killing of over a hundred rhinoceros across three countries, had barricaded himself in a compound with twelve armed guards. He had heard the reports. He had heard that something was coming — something that moved through the jungle like a ghost and hit like a freight train. He doubled his guard. He activated his emergency extraction plan.

She came through the compound wall. Not around it. Not over it. Through it. Kavach hit the concrete block at a dead run, and the wall exploded inward in a shower of dust and rubble. She emerged from the debris cloud like something from a myth — armor scored, tattoo blazing violet in the dust-choked air, eyes utterly calm. The guards opened fire. She raised Kavach and walked forward into the storm of bullets with the slow, deliberate pace of a rhino crossing its territory. Unstoppable. Unhurried. Inevitable.

Day six and seven: the final cells. The couriers, the middlemen, the money handlers. She found them all. Every horn was recovered. Every member of the syndicate's operational chain, from the pilot to the field commander, was delivered to the authorities — bruised,

terrified, but alive. All alive. Because Kamalavarna, even in her deepest fury, was still the girl who had sung a rhinoceros to sleep in a thunderstorm. She would not kill. She would break, bend, shatter, and terrify. But she would not take a life.

"I have fought warriors from six continents. I have sparred with beings that are not human. I have never, in my entire career, been as frightened as I was watching the footage of her coming through that wall."

— Simhavikrama of Gujarat, on viewing the Nagaland compound raid

Chapter VII

A Choice That Reveals Character

The trail led upward. Past the foot soldiers and the field commanders, past the logistics networks and the bribed officials, to a name that everyone in Assam knew. Bhuvaneshwar Deka. Member of the regional development council. Patron of three orphanages, four schools, and the very wildlife conservation trust that funded Kaziranga's ranger patrols. The man who gave speeches about protecting the rhinoceros while secretly owning the corporation that sold their horns to the highest bidder.

Kamalavarna found him in his Guwahati penthouse, packing for a flight to Dubai. He was not afraid. He was a man who had purchased fear all his life and considered himself immune to it. He looked at her — battered, exhausted, her tattoo pulsing with diminished but steady light, Kavach dented and scarred from seven days of continuous combat — and he smiled.

"You can't touch me," he said. "I fund half the institutions in this state. Arrest me, and a hundred projects collapse. Schools close. Hospitals lose their donors. The very rangers who protect your precious rhinos lose their salaries. I am the system, girl. Kill me, and you kill the things you love."

She stood in his doorway for a long time. The rage was still there — the rhino's rage, vast and hot and simple. Charge. Crush. End the threat. It would have been so easy. One swing of Kavach. One step forward with the momentum she had carried across three states and seven days. The rhino in her blood screamed for it.

But the lotus in her hair whispered something different.

She planted Kavach's base on the marble floor of his penthouse with a crack that split the tile and echoed through the building. She stood there, immovable, and spoke three words

that would reshape the politics of northeast India for a generation: "Then the system changes."

She did not kill him. She did not even strike him. She recorded everything — every document in his office, every communication on his phone, every financial record that connected his conservation trust to the syndicate's accounts. She walked out of his penthouse carrying the truth, and she delivered it not to the police (whom he owned) or to the courts (which he influenced) but to the people. To every village, every tea garden, every fishing community along the Brahmaputra. She let the people decide.

Bhuvaneshwar Deka fled the state within seventy-two hours. His assets were frozen by a court order obtained by a coalition of tribal leaders, tea workers' unions, and wildlife activists who had been fighting him for decades but had never had the evidence. The institutions he funded were rebuilt under transparent governance. The system did not collapse. It was rebuilt. Stronger, cleaner, and no longer built on the bones of dead rhinoceros.

"The rhinoceros charges. It is in its nature. But Kamalavarna chose not to charge. She chose to stand. And standing, she changed more than any charge could have."

— Meghanadi of Meghalaya, on the Deka Affair

Chapter VIII

Kaziranga Veterinary Centre — Forty-Three Days

The bullet had lodged two millimeters from Vajrakavacha's spinal cord. The veterinary team — three surgeons, two wildlife veterinarians, and a trauma specialist flown in from Kolkata — spent eleven hours in surgery. They worked under canvas in the field, because moving a three-thousand-kilogram patient to a hospital was not possible. They used equipment designed for elephants, modified on the fly. They nearly lost him twice — once when his heart rate dropped below twenty beats per minute, and once when an abscess from the tranquilizer injection site ruptured mid-surgery and filled the chest cavity with fluid.

Kamalavarna sat outside the surgical tent for the entire eleven hours. She did not eat. She did not drink. She sat cross-legged in the mud with Kavach across her knees and her bare feet pressed flat against the earth, feeling — she was certain she could feel — the rhythm of his heartbeat through the ground. When the surgeons came out, grey-faced and exhausted,

and told her he had survived the operation, she nodded once and asked when she could see him.

She did not leave his side for forty-three days. She slept beside his enclosure on a cot that the rangers brought her, though she rarely used it, preferring to sit with her back against the fence where she could reach through and rest her hand on his flank. She monitored his breathing through the night. She changed his dressings with a gentleness that astonished the veterinary staff, her enormous, calloused, shield-scarred hands moving with the delicacy of a surgeon as she cleaned the wounds and applied the poultices she prepared from herbs she gathered in the grasslands.

He could not stand for three weeks. The bullet's proximity to his spine had caused swelling that compressed the nerves to his hind legs, and for those three weeks he lay on his side, breathing, eating the grass and fruit she hand-fed him, watching her with his small, dark, patient eyes. She talked to him constantly — not in the language of snorts and huffs they had developed together, but in Assamese, in Bodo, in Hindi, in whatever words came to her. She told him about the hunt. She told him about Deka. She told him about the schools that would be rebuilt and the rhinos that would be safer. She told him that she needed him to stand up.

On the twenty-second day, he tried. His front legs folded beneath him, and he levered his massive forequarters up, his muscles trembling with effort. His hind legs twitched. He strained. And he collapsed. The sound of three thousand kilograms hitting the ground shook the enclosure and brought the veterinary team running. Kamalavarna waved them away. She pressed her forehead against his horn and whispered something that no one else could hear.

He tried again on the twenty-third day. And the twenty-fourth. Each time, his hind legs held a fraction longer before failing. Each time, Kamalavarna was there, her hands on his flank, her voice steady, her presence as immovable as the shield she carried.

On the thirty-ninth day, he stood.

It was not graceful. His hind legs shook violently. He swayed. His breathing came in great bellowing gasps. But he was upright, his four feet on the earth, his horn pointed at the sky, and he let out a sound that the rangers would later describe as the loudest vocalization they had ever recorded from a rhinoceros — a roar that echoed across the floodplain and

brought every rhino within earshot to their feet in response. A call of the living. An answer to the earth.

Kamalavarna's tattoo completed itself in that moment. The final stage — the full-body rhinoceros, covering her from shoulder to ankle, from spine to sternum — emerged not in battle fury or grief-stricken power, but in quiet, steady, stubborn love. Stage Four. Full Body. Not earned through victory, but through forty-three days of refusing to leave.

"Her full mark came not when she fought. Not when she raged. It came when she waited. The Chihnachakra measures the depth of the bond, and there is no bond deeper than the one tested by patience and proven by presence."

— Dakshinamurthi Archive, Commentary on the Kamalavarna Ascension

Chapter IX

Kaziranga, Every Morning

The mist rises from the Brahmaputra before the sun does. It crawls across the floodplain in soft grey rivers, pooling in the low places, threading through the elephant grass like the ghosts of old waters. In the minutes before dawn, the world is entirely grey — grey sky, grey mist, grey grass, grey earth — and the only sounds are the drip of condensation from the leaves and the slow, deep breathing of the largest animal in the park.

She emerges from the ranger station at the same time every morning: twenty minutes before sunrise, when the eastern sky is just beginning to soften from black to charcoal. She wears her armor. She carries Kavach. The full-body tattoo, visible on her arms and throat above the armor's neckline, gives off a faint purple luminescence in the pre-dawn darkness, like foxfire in the marshes, like something that belongs to the earth itself.

He is always waiting. At the edge of the compound, where the maintained ground gives way to wild grass, Vajrakavacha stands in the mist like a boulder that has learned to breathe. He is scarred now. A long silver line runs along his left flank where the bullet's damage healed but left its record. He walks with a barely perceptible limp in his right hind leg — noticeable only if you watch him closely, and Kamalavarna always watches him closely. His horn is as long and dark and magnificent as ever. His eyes, small and deep-set in their folds of armored skin, are bright and steady.

She places her hand on his snout. He exhales. The warm breath washes over her palm, carrying the smell of wet grass and crushed reeds and the deep, animal warmth that has

been her compass since she was three years old. She leans forward and presses her forehead to his horn for a single breath. He rumbles. She steps back.

They walk. Side by side, at the rhino's pace — deliberate, unhurried, each step placed with the weight of absolute certainty. Her footsteps match his. Left, right, left, right, the four-beat rhythm of a rhinoceros walk interlocked with the two-beat rhythm of a human stride, creating a pattern that the earth itself has memorized. Her breathing matches his. Deep, slow, measured, filling the belly before the chest, the exhalation longer than the inhalation, the way she learned to breathe when she was six years old and first ran alongside the herd in the morning light.

The sun breaches the eastern hills. Gold light floods the floodplain. The elephant grass catches fire — not flame but color, the stalks turning from grey to amber to pure shining gold as the light moves across them in a wave. Birds erupt from the reeds: egrets, herons, cormorants, rising in white and grey clouds against the newborn blue of the sky. The river glitters. The mist burns away. And two figures move through the golden world, one enormous and grey and armored in the hide that evolution spent fifty million years perfecting, one tall and broad and armored in steel and leather and a tattoo that tells the story of a love that not even bullets could end.

They patrol the eastern perimeter first, then the southern marsh, then the central grasslands. Six kilometers in two hours. She checks for tracks — human tracks, vehicle tracks, anything that does not belong. He checks with his nose, lifting his head to sample the air with the olfactory equipment of a creature whose sense of smell is thirty times more sensitive than a human's. Between them, nothing enters Kaziranga without their knowledge.

At the end of the patrol, they return to the eastern marsh where they first met. She sits on the bank. He wades into the shallows, lowering his massive body into the cool water with a sigh of contentment that vibrates through the ground. She watches him wallow, grey hide glistening, and somewhere in her chest the anchor holds, steady and warm and heavier than any shield.

"Every dawn is a promise that the world survived the night. Every patrol is a promise that we will make sure it survives the next one."

— Kamalavarna, in a letter to the Regional Leader Arunodaya

The Darkness Beyond

A Shadow Behind the Syndicate

It was Sundarvani of West Bengal who noticed the discrepancy. The Fishing Cat champion, whose patience and eye for detail rivaled any intelligence analyst, had been reviewing the financial records Kamalavarna had recovered from Bhuvaneshwar Deka's office. The money trail made no sense. The syndicate was profitable — rhinoceros horn fetched astronomical prices on the black market — but the profit margins did not justify the military-grade equipment, the satellite imagery, or the operational sophistication of the Kaziranga raid. Someone was subsidizing the operation. Someone was paying far more for the horns than the medical market warranted.

The deeper she dug, the stranger it became. The rhino horns were not entering the traditional supply chain. They were not being ground into powder for folk remedies or carved into status objects for collectors. They were being shipped to a location that appeared on no map — a facility in the mountains of central Asia, disguised as a mining operation, that consumed animal parts of very specific types: rhinoceros horn, tiger bone, elephant ivory, bear bile. All from bonded animals. All from creatures that had formed the spirit bridge with their human counterparts.

The facility was not harvesting medicine. It was harvesting the bond itself — the spiritual residue that accumulated in the bones and horns and tusks of animals who had shared the Chihnachakra connection with human warriors for generations. Whatever they were building in that mountain, it required the essence of the covenant between human and beast. And they needed a great deal of it.

When Kamalavarna received Sundarvani's report, she read it three times. Then she walked to the eastern marsh where Vajrakavacha was wallowing in the morning light, and she sat beside him and pressed her hand against his scarred flank and felt the steady rhythm of his ancient heart. The poachers had not come for money. They had come for something far worse. And whatever ritual or weapon or abomination was being assembled in that mountain, it was powered by the very thing she loved most: the bond between a human and her beast.

She stood. She collected Kavach. She looked east, toward the mountains that rose beyond the floodplain, beyond the hills, beyond the borders of the lands she knew. Something was stirring in those mountains. Something that fed on the oldest magic in the world. And Kamalavarna, the Lotus Shield, the Horn of the Brahmaputra, the girl who had once placed her tiny hands on the snout of an unkillable thing and found the only gentleness it had to

give — this woman understood, with the same deep certainty that had guided her feet through the grasslands since she was six years old, that defending Kaziranga would no longer be enough.

The Void Maw approaches. The stars are disappearing. And someone, somewhere, is trying to accelerate its arrival using the stolen souls of sacred beasts.

The story continues in the Hulmane-The-Saga Saga...

When the shield must defend more than one park, one herd, one bond — can it hold?

Kamalavarna's journey with Vajrakavacha follows the four-phase bonding process that all tattoo-bearers undergo — but few complete with such depth or devotion.

Kamalavarna serves as the anchor of the Northeast coalition under Regional Leader Arunodaya, the Dawn Commander. While Arunodaya leads with diplomacy and his unprecedented understanding of all eight northeastern cultures, it is Kamalavarna who holds the line. Literally. When the northeast heroes stand together, she stands at the front with Kavach raised, and nothing passes.

Her discovery of the dark ritual behind the poaching syndicate places her at the center of one of the saga's most dangerous threads. The stolen bond-essence, the mountain facility, and its connection to the approaching Void Maw represent a threat that goes beyond any single region or kingdom. Kamalavarna must now carry her shield beyond Kaziranga — into the Grand Council chambers, onto the world stage, and perhaps into the stars themselves.

The girl who touched the unkillable thing may be the only one who can stand before the force that kills everything. The Void Maw is unstoppable. Kamalavarna has spent her entire life learning what to do when faced with the unstoppable. She does not move.

Hulmane-The-Saga — The Great Assembly of Warriors

Megha Maata — The Serpent And The Root Bridge

Meghalaya is a matrilineal society. Property passes through the mother. The youngest daughter inherits the ancestral home. Men are respected but women rule. This is not a modern experiment — it is an ancient tradition, and the living root bridges of Meghalaya are its physical proof: structures that take fifty years to grow, planted by grandmothers for grandchildren they will never meet. This is how women build — not for themselves, but for the future.

U Thlen offers a different model. Wealth now. Power now. Blood now.

Meghanadi's battle against U Thlen is not a battle of weapons — it is a battle of timescales. U Thlen thrives in urgency: feed me NOW, sacrifice NOW, prosper NOW. The matriarchal wisdom of Meghalaya operates on generations: plant the root NOW, and your great-granddaughter will have a bridge.

The serpent reformed in the deepest cave of the Jaintia Hills, pieced together from centuries of small sacrifices. A shop-keeper who bled his nephew for a profitable season. A farmer who bled her cousin for a bountiful harvest. Each drop of blood was a scale, and U Thlen's scales number in the millions.

When he emerged, the clouded leopards of Meghalaya — usually invisible, usually silent — screamed from every tree in the canopy. Hill Mynas repeated the scream until the entire forest rang with alarm.

Meghanadi met him at the longest root bridge in Meghalaya — a structure that had been growing for 500 years, planted by a woman whose name no one remembers. The bridge spanned a gorge so deep that clouds formed inside it. U Thlen coiled at one end, his body blocking the passage. His mouth opened, and inside was darkness — not the darkness of a throat, but the darkness of every corrupt bargain ever made.

"Join me," he whispered. "Your matriarchy is beautiful, but it is slow. I can make Meghalaya the richest kingdom in India by morning."

Meghanadi's answer was lightning. Her cloud-staff drew a bolt from the perpetual storm-clouds above, and the bolt struck U Thlen's head — but the serpent's scales, made from human blood, absorbed the electricity. He laughed, and the laugh echoed through the gorge like the sound of bones breaking.

The root bridge itself saved her. Fifty years of growth, five hundred years of patience, channeled through living wood that had never asked for anything and never taken a life. The roots moved. Not fast — roots never move fast — but inevitably. They wrapped around U Thlen's body and held him, not crushing but simply containing, the way a grandmother holds a screaming child.

U Thlen thrashes still. The root bridge holds. And Meghanadi plants new roots every morning, growing the bridge stronger, inch by patient inch.

Her daughter wants to leave Meghalaya for Nagaland. In a matrilineal society, a daughter's departure is not just personal — it is a potential end of the line. Meghanadi must choose between holding her daughter and holding U Thlen.

The clouds gather. The Hill Mynas repeat whatever they hear. And in the gorge, the root bridge grows.

Sangai Nata — The Last Dance Of The Sangai

The Sangai deer dances on water. Not literally — it walks on the phumdi, the floating vegetation mats of Loktak Lake, and its steps are so light that it appears to dance on the lake's surface. There are fewer than 300 Sangai left, and each one dances with the knowledge that it may be the last of its kind.

Moirangthem understands this intimately. His Thang-Ta swordplay is modeled on the Sangai's movements — the delicate steps, the sudden leaps, the way the deer turns its entire body in a single fluid motion. When he fights on the phumdi, with the lake shifting beneath his feet and his swords cutting arcs of light through the mist, it is impossible to tell where the dance ends and the combat begins.

Thangjing-Lai appeared on the night of Lai Haraoba — the festival where Manipuris dance to honor the forest deities. The entire village was dancing when they noticed a figure at the edge of the firelight: tall, antlered, moving with a grace that made even the master dancers freeze in awe. Then the figure stepped into the circle, and the compulsion began.

People danced. They could not stop. The rhythm was not in the music — it was in the air, in the vibration of the earth, in the beating of their own hearts. Moirangthem felt it too — his feet moving before his mind consented, his swords swinging in patterns he had never learned. But his years of Thang-Ta discipline gave him something the villagers lacked: the ability to redirect the compulsion rather than resist it.

He danced toward Thangjing-Lai instead of away, and their duel was the most beautiful thing anyone in Manipur had ever seen. Two dancers — one human, one divine — moving in perfect opposition on the floating islands of Loktak, their steps so light that the water barely rippled. Mrs. Hume's Pheasants, the rarest birds in the region, emerged from hiding to watch — and they do not emerge for anything.

The duel ended in a draw. Thangjing-Lai vanished at dawn (the corrupted dance-god cannot exist in sunlight — only in the twilight between), and the villagers collapsed, alive but exhausted. Three elderly people did not survive the night's dancing.

Moirangthem now trains to resist the compulsion completely — not through force but through mastery. If he can learn the pattern of Thangjing-Lai's dance, he can create a counter-pattern. A dance that un-dances.

His family's secret Sangai breeding program may hold the key: the deer's own movements create a natural counter-rhythm. If the Sangai can be persuaded to dance at the same time as Thangjing-Lai, their pattern — the original, uncorrupted divine dance — may overwrite his corrupted version.

But persuading 300 endangered deer to dance on command requires something Moirangthem has never had: patience. The Sangai dance when they choose. And they are choosing less and less frequently, as if they know their world is ending.

The phumdi float. The lake waits. And somewhere in the mist, antlered shadows move in patterns that are either salvation or destruction, depending on the direction of the dance.

Tlawmngaihna Desh — The Man Who Could Not Refuse

Tlawmngaihna is Mizoram's gift to the world — a concept so beautiful that it has no exact translation. It means: the instinct to help, even when helping costs you. The inability to walk past suffering. The compulsion to sacrifice comfort for another's survival. Every Mizo child learns it. Tlangvala was born already knowing it.

His wife died during the Mautam — the bamboo famine that comes every 48 years when all the bamboo flowers simultaneously, attracting rats that devour the crop. Tlangvala could have saved his family's grain store. But when his neighbors came asking for rice, he could not refuse. When strangers came asking for shelter, he could not refuse. His wife, weakened by giving away her own portions, died holding a bowl of rice she had hidden for their children — and even that, the children gave to a hungry stranger at the door.

The cruelty of Tlawmngaihna is this: it can be exploited. And Chhinlung-Naag knows it.

The serpent does not attack Mizoram with armies. He attacks with need. He sends people to Tlangvala's door — women with babies, elderly men with empty stomachs, children with hollow eyes. Each one is a projection, a psychic mirage drawn from the cave's memory of every hungry person who ever lived. And Tlangvala helps each one, because he cannot refuse, and each one takes a little more of his strength.

His son wants to leave the mountains for the plains, where Tlawmngaihna is not a cultural mandate but a personal choice. "You are being eaten alive, Father," the boy says. "You give everything and keep nothing. This is not service — it is self-destruction."

Tlangvala knows his son is right. But knowing does not change the compulsion. The serow stands on impossible cliffs because it was made for cliffs. Tlangvala serves because he was made for service.

The Battle of the Cave Mouth was fought at the legendary Chhinlung entrance — a cave in the earth so deep that sound enters but does not return. Chhinlung-Naag emerged as a serpent the width of a river, speaking in the voices of every dead Mizo ancestor, calling the people home to the underground where there is no hunger, no loss, and no need for Tlawmngaihna because there is no need for anything.

Tlangvala fought the serpent with his bamboo staff and lost. Not because he was weaker — because the serpent asked him for mercy, and he could not refuse.

Pu Vangchhia's spirit-pattern in the bamboo spells a warning: the next time Chhinlung-Naag asks for mercy, the correct answer is not yes. The correct answer is the bamboo's answer — bend, absorb, and spring back.

Tlangvala trains with bamboo now, learning its secret: you can give everything and still return to your original shape.

If you are made of the right material.

Tri Pura — The Engineer And The Flying Cities

Tripura means "Three Cities," and the state has never forgotten it. In mythology, the three flying cities of the Asuras — one of gold, one of silver, one of iron — circled the earth like mechanical moons, invincible until Shiva pierced all three with a single arrow at the precise moment of their alignment.

Tripurari grew up on this story and asked the question no one else thought to ask: "If the cities were destroyed by alignment, could they be rebuilt to avoid alignment?"

He was twelve. He had already built a working model of the three cities from bamboo and string. By twenty, he had rebuilt the city's ancient water-wheel system using modern engineering principles. By thirty, he had invented the Triyantra crossbow and the self-repairing wall technology that makes Tripura's borders the most secure in the Northeast.

Tripura-Asura returned because of Tripurari — specifically, because Tripurari's engineering genius sent a signal into the mythological realm that someone was rebuilding what Shiva had destroyed. The demon sensed a kindred spirit: another engineer, another builder, another mind that believed creation was greater than destruction.

But where Tripurari builds defenses, Tripura-Asura builds weapons. The three flying cities he has reconstructed are smaller than their mythological originals — about the size of large boats, not actual cities — but their alignment beam is still devastating. A test-firing leveled a hilltop. The Green Imperial Pigeons that nested on that hill scattered across three states, carrying the warning.

Tripurari's response was characteristically analytical. He calculated the alignment cycle, mapped the fortresses' flight patterns, and designed a countermeasure: three grounded towers that, when the fortresses align, create a counter-frequency that disrupts the beam. The engineering is sound. The problem is time.

The next alignment is in three months. The towers are only half-built. And Tripura-Asura, learning from mythological mistakes, has begun varying his flight patterns to prevent prediction.

The Maharaja's Ghost walks the construction site at midnight, checking the foundations. "My bridge fell because I trusted the wrong engineer," he repeats. "You are the right engineer. But the question is whether you are building fast enough."

Tripurari's father was disgraced by a bridge collapse that killed seventeen people. Tripurari has spent his life proving it was sabotage — and he now suspects Tripura-Asura was the saboteur, testing Tripura's engineering resilience centuries before revealing himself.

The Phayre's Langurs watch from the canopy with their spectacled eyes, tracking the flying fortresses' movements and reporting to the Langur-Scouts. The langurs have noticed something Tripurari hasn't: the fortresses' flight paths are spelling something in the sky.

When decoded, the message reads: "One arrow destroyed three cities. What destroys one engineer?"

Tripurari does not know the answer. He is building anyway.